

# Session 14: A Challenging Passage on Tongues

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## Key Takeaways

- 1 Corinthians 14:20-26 presents unique interpretive challenges.
- Paul quotes from Isaiah 28:11-12, but the phrasing does not match any known manuscripts.
- It's possible 1 Corinthians 14:21-22 is another place where Paul quotes the Corinthians.

## The Gift of Tongues

In 1 Corinthians 14:20, Paul revisits the theme of children and growing up. Don't be childish in your minds (grow up), only be infants in evil. In thinking, be fully grown or complete (Greek: τέλειοι). Then he cites the Law.

## Paul References Isaiah 28:11-12

This is a notoriously difficult section. J.B. Phillips rewrote 1 Corinthians 14:22, changing Paul's words to the opposite because he thought it was "a slip of the pen on the part of Paul, or, more probably, a copyist's error." (Phillips, 1960).

There is a huge amount of disagreement here as to what Paul might be saying to the Corinthians through citing this verse. The question we are faced with is how might it make sense that tongues are a "sign" for unbelievers given what we have already heard?

### **1 Corinthians 14:22 NIV**

Tongues, then, are a sign, not for believers but for unbelievers; prophecy, however, is not for unbelievers but for believers.

Verse 22 begins with ὥστε (Greek: *hoste*—therefore) linking this verse to the previous one, the quote from Isaiah. Here we read a contrast between just believing and unbelieving people.

## Understanding the Quotation From Isaiah

One really complicating factor is that the Hebrew text, the Masoretic Text (MT), is different from the Greek text, the Septuagint (LXX), and the quote in 1 Corinthians 14 is different from them both. (The Masoretic Text is the authoritative form of the Hebrew Bible for Rabbinic Judaism and the Septuagint in the 3rd and 2nd centuries B.C.E.).

Debate centers on:

1. Paul's use of the Isaiah text
2. The meaning of σημεῖον (sign)
3. The meaning of ἀπίστοις (unbelievers) as used in the a) assertions and b) the illustrations.

## The Use of the Isaiah Text

"Most commentators point out that the Isaiah quote diverges substantially from the MT and the LXX. Either it is quoted loosely or else from a Greek translation other than the LXX."

Johanson, Bruce (1979). "Tongues, A Sign for Unbelievers?" *New Testament Studies*, 25. 181.

Origen claimed to have found the text in a different Greek version of the Bible apart from the LXX, but this has not been verified (See *Philocalia*, IX. 2).

### 1 Corinthians 14:21 RSV

By men of strange tongues and by the lips of foreigners  
will I speak to this people, and even then they will not listen to me, says the Lord.

### Isaiah 28:11-12 Masoretic Text

<sup>11</sup> Nay, but by men of strange lips and with an alien tongue  
the Lord will speak to this people, <sup>12</sup> to whom he has said, "This is rest; give rest to the weary; and this is repose"; yet they would not hear.

### Isaiah 28:11-12 LXX

<sup>11</sup> through the contemptuous speech of lips, through another tongue  
for they will speak to this people,  
<sup>12</sup> saying to them  
"This is rest for the hungry; and this is the calamity";  
but they would not hear.

The changes we read in 1 Corinthians include:

1. 1 Corinthians has "I will speak" in the place of "the Lord will speak" (MT) and "they will speak" (LXX).
2. 1 Corinthians omits the intelligible message spoken by the "Lord" (MT) and "they" (LXX) to which "this people" refuse to listen in both cases.
3. 1 Corinthians adds the authoritative phrase λέγει κύριος (says the Lord) found neither in the MT nor in the LXX.

## Is Paul Quoting Loosely From Memory Or Deliberately Adapting?

"The texts of the MT, LXX, and NT differ so much that definite signs of literary dependence are difficult to find. ... He deviates from all known Hebrew and Greek texts ..."

Lanier, D.E. (1991). "With Stammering Lips and Another Tongue." *Criswell Theological Review*, 5. 269-270.

There is a proposed exception from an unknown text that we don't have access to, but that's an argument from silence. What is the effect of the changes? The thrust of what we read here is closer to the MT, that God is speaking, is not being heard, and this brings judgement.

Lanier writes that Paul adapts the text to make it a much more forceful rendition of the idea that God is speaking (I instead of "he" in the MT and "they" in the LXX) so that "even though YHWH himself made the appeal, they would not hearken to me, says the Lord." (Lanier, 1991).

"We should ... note that the omission of the intelligible message has the effect of making the object of the hearer's refusal to listen, not the intelligible message as in the MT and LXX, but the unintelligible speech of 'foreigners' through whom God will speak. The addition of οὕτως [thus] and the use of the compound εἰσακούειν [to really listen] in place of the simple ἀκούειν [to listen] makes the fact that the people will not listen even more emphatic."

Johanson, Bruce (1979). "Tongues, A Sign for Unbelievers?" *New Testament Studies*, 25. 182.

## Tongues as a "Sign"

If we think that Paul is making a point about tongues being a "sign" for unbelievers based on this text that we have, what kind of sign might that be? A negative or a positive sign or something else?

### Tongues as a Negative Sign

Lanier argues that we can make sense of it if we study the background to Isaiah 28. "[Isaiah 28:1-6](#) constitutes one oracle versus the northern kingdom, Ephraim, and leads to an indictment of Judah itself" (Lanier, 1991).

The people will not listen to the prophets of God, therefore, they will be subject to having to "endure a different lesson from God, mediated through babbling masters." They are going to go into exile to the Assyrians (Lanier, 1991).

"[Isaiah 28:11-12](#) illustrates 'from the Law' this exact phenomenon: untranslated tongues harden unbelievers in their unbelief, whereas clear prophecy has always been intended to build up those who will believe and apply it."

Lanier, D.E. (1991). "With Stammering Lips and Another Tongue." *Criswell Theological Review*, 5. 269-270.

Thus, Lanier understands tongues functioning as a sign of judgement on unbelievers with a parallel of a negative sign in the Hebrew Bible. Lanier recognizes that the uninterpreted Assyrian language of [Isaiah 28](#) was a form of punishment for unbelief (Lanier, 1991). However, he proposes that we see "sign" in 1 Corinthians as a neutral term, "connoting evidence of divine activity whether for judgement or blessing" (Lanier, 1991).

He argues that uninterpreted tongues will put them under judgement because they won't be able to understand, but interpreted tongues will be a positive sign.

Johanson argues that this is the Corinthian view, and Paul rebukes them for their childishness in the use of tongues.

What if the quote is a misquote by the Corinthians to justify their speaking in tongues and people not understanding? They are justifying all speaking in tongues all at once even if those on the outside and unbelievers will have no idea what they're saying.

## **Reflection Question**

Do your best to summarize the different interpretations of this passage. Which of the interpretations do you find the most convincing?